



Common Skin Diseases

A Simple Home Guide to Recognizing Symptoms,
Caring for Your Skin, and Knowing When to See a Doctor

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What's Inside

Skin issues are one of the most common reasons people search for medical advice — and one of the most confusing to self-diagnose, since so many conditions look alike at first glance. This short guide covers six of the most common skin conditions we see at TalkDoc: what they typically look like, what tends to trigger them, simple things you can try at home, and — most importantly — the warning signs that mean it's time to speak with a doctor rather than wait it out.

- 1. Eczema (Atopic Dermatitis)**
- 2. Acne**
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- 5. Urticaria (Hives)**
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This guide is for general education only. It is not a diagnosis, and it is not a substitute for seeing a licensed doctor. Skin conditions can look similar but need very different treatments, so if you're ever unsure, the safest next step is always to have a doctor actually look at it.

1. Eczema (Atopic Dermatitis)

Eczema is a long-term condition that makes patches of skin dry, itchy, and inflamed. It's especially common in children but can appear at any age, and it often runs in families alongside asthma or hay fever.

Common Symptoms

- Dry, scaly, or cracked skin
- Intense itching, often worse at night
- Red to brownish-gray patches, commonly on hands, feet, wrists, and the folds of elbows and knees
- Small raised bumps that may leak fluid when scratched

Common Triggers

- Dry weather or low humidity
- Harsh soaps, detergents, or fragranced products
- Stress
- Sweating and overheating
- Certain fabrics, especially wool or synthetic material

Home Care Tips

- Moisturize at least twice a day with a fragrance-free cream
- Take short, lukewarm showers instead of long hot ones
- Pat skin dry gently rather than rubbing
- Avoid known triggers and harsh soaps
- Keep fingernails short to reduce damage from scratching

See a Doctor If...

- The skin looks infected — increasing redness, warmth, swelling, or pus
- It doesn't improve after a couple of weeks of consistent home care
- It's severe enough to disrupt sleep or daily life
- You develop a fever alongside the rash

2. Acne

Acne happens when hair follicles become clogged with oil and dead skin cells, often alongside bacteria. It's most common during the teenage years due to hormonal changes, but it can affect adults too.

Common Symptoms

- Whiteheads and blackheads
- Small red, tender bumps (papules)
- Pimples with pus at their tips (pustules)
- Larger, painful lumps under the skin (cysts or nodules) in more severe cases

Common Triggers

- Hormonal changes (puberty, menstrual cycle, pregnancy)
- Excess oil production
- Certain cosmetics or hair products that clog pores
- Friction from helmets, straps, or tight clothing
- Some medications

Home Care Tips

- Wash the affected area gently twice a day — avoid scrubbing
- Use non-comedogenic ("won't clog pores") skincare and makeup
- Avoid picking or popping spots, which increases scarring risk
- Be patient — most over-the-counter treatments take 4-6 weeks to show results

See a Doctor If...

- Acne is painful, deep, or leaving scars
- It's not improving after 2-3 months of consistent over-the-counter care
- It's affecting your confidence or mental health
- You notice sudden, severe breakouts that are unusual for you

3. Contact Dermatitis

Contact dermatitis is a reaction that happens when your skin touches something that irritates it or triggers an allergic response — anything from soap to jewelry to plants.

Common Symptoms

- Red rash, often with clearly defined edges matching where contact occurred
- Itching, sometimes intense
- Dry, cracked, or scaly patches
- Blisters that may ooze or crust in more severe cases

Common Triggers

- Soaps, detergents, and cleaning products
- Jewelry containing nickel
- Certain plants (such as poison ivy)
- Latex or rubber
- Fragrances and cosmetic ingredients

Home Care Tips

- Wash the area with mild soap and cool water as soon as possible after contact
- Avoid scratching, and keep the area moisturized
- Remove or avoid the suspected trigger
- A cool, damp cloth can help ease itching

See a Doctor If...

- The rash covers a large area or is on the face or genitals
- You have trouble breathing or swelling of the face/lips/tongue (seek emergency care immediately)
- The rash is worsening, spreading, or shows signs of infection
- It doesn't improve within a week of avoiding the trigger

4. Fungal Skin Infections (Ringworm)

Despite the name, ringworm isn't caused by a worm — it's a fungal infection that can affect the skin, scalp, or nails, and it spreads fairly easily through direct contact or shared items.

Common Symptoms

- A ring-shaped rash with a raised, scaly border and a clearer center
- Itching
- Red, scaly, or cracked skin
- On the scalp, patchy hair loss may occur

Common Triggers

- Direct skin contact with an infected person or animal
- Sharing towels, combs, or clothing
- Warm, humid environments and excessive sweating
- Walking barefoot in shared damp areas like locker rooms

Home Care Tips

- Keep the area clean and dry
- Over-the-counter antifungal creams are often effective for mild cases
- Avoid sharing towels, clothing, or bedding while infected
- Wash hands after touching the affected area to avoid spreading it

See a Doctor If...

- The rash doesn't improve after 2 weeks of antifungal cream
- It affects the scalp or nails, which usually need prescription treatment
- It spreads rapidly or covers a large area
- You have a weakened immune system or diabetes

5. Urticaria (Hives)

Hives are raised, itchy welts that appear suddenly on the skin, usually as an allergic reaction, though sometimes the exact cause is never identified.

Common Symptoms

- Raised, red or skin-colored welts that can appear anywhere on the body
- Intense itching
- Welts that vary in size and can merge into larger patches
- Individual welts often fade within 24 hours, though new ones may appear

Common Triggers

- Certain foods (nuts, shellfish, eggs, etc.)
- Medications
- Insect stings or bites
- Infections
- Stress, heat, or pressure on the skin

Home Care Tips

- A cool compress can help ease itching
- Avoid known triggers
- Loose, breathable clothing can reduce irritation
- Over-the-counter antihistamines may help mild cases

See a Doctor If...

- You have swelling of the lips, tongue, throat, or trouble breathing (this is an emergency — seek care immediately)
- Hives last longer than 6 weeks (chronic hives)
- They keep recurring without a clear trigger
- They're accompanied by fever or joint pain

6. Psoriasis

Psoriasis is a long-term condition where skin cells build up faster than usual, forming thick, scaly patches. It's related to the immune system and tends to flare up and settle down over time.

Common Symptoms

- Raised, red patches covered with silvery-white scales
- Dry skin that may crack and bleed
- Itching, burning, or soreness
- Thickened, pitted, or ridged nails in some cases

Common Triggers

- Stress
- Skin injury (cuts, sunburn, scratches)
- Certain medications
- Infections
- Cold, dry weather

Home Care Tips

- Moisturize regularly to reduce dryness and scaling
- Try to identify and manage your personal flare-up triggers
- Gentle sun exposure can help some people (check with a doctor first)
- Avoid scratching or picking at patches

See a Doctor If...

- Patches are widespread, painful, or affecting your joints
- Over-the-counter moisturizers aren't controlling flare-ups
- You notice joint pain or stiffness alongside skin symptoms
- It's affecting your quality of life or mental health

7. When to Book a Consultation

Reading about a condition can help you understand what might be going on, but it can never replace an actual examination — many skin conditions look alike, and the right treatment depends on getting the right diagnosis. As a general rule, it's worth speaking to a doctor if:

- A rash is spreading, worsening, or not improving with basic home care
- You have signs of infection — increasing redness, warmth, swelling, or pus
- You're in pain, or the condition is affecting your daily life or sleep
- You have a fever alongside any skin symptoms
- You simply aren't sure what you're dealing with

Talk to a Real Doctor from Home

TalkDoc connects you with licensed doctors for consultations, prescriptions, and referrals — no appointment or waiting room needed. Whatever is going on with your skin, we can help you get a real answer.

Visit talkdoc.ng to get started.

This guide is provided for general educational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always seek the advice of a qualified doctor with any questions you may have regarding a medical condition.